when it won 120 seats. It now had ‘visions of forming a Government at the Centre’ and needed to chart a clearer economic vision to acquire greater ‘legitimacy’ in the electoral arena.[67]

With the reforms, the BJP was confronted with a serious ideological challenge. In 1992, the party’s leaders realised that, having set the agenda for two successive elections with the revivalist Ram Janmabhoomi movement, they found themselves ‘ill-equipped on economic policies’ and ‘found it increasingly difficult to participate in the debate on the changes initiated by Dr Manmohan Singh’. So, they engaged in a series of top-level meetings to redefine their economic policy, starting in Sarnath in March 1992, then Baroda in March and finally Gandhinagar in May that year.

A little over a year before that, Ayodhya had reverberated with the BJP slogans of ‘*Yeh to bas jhanki hai, Mathura Kashi baki hai*’ (This is just the trailer, Mathura and Kashi [temples] are still left). The fact that the first gathering of 150 top party leaders to discuss a new BJP post-reform economic policy met at the Buddhist centre of Sarnath (and not the nearby temple town of Kashi) was symbolic in more ways than one. As journalist Nilanjan Mukhopadhyay reported at the time, after ‘following a confrontationist path for close to five years’, the BJP was grappling with ‘new issues and realities’ as it sought to position itself as a more centrist party and a serious challenger to the Congress.[68] This was the party’s third major economic vision statement—the first came in the 1970s, drafted for the Jan Sangh by Subramanian Swamy, and the other in 1986.

These conclaves showed that, throughout 1991-92, the BJP’s economic policy remained in ferment. On 14 March 1992, for example, L.K. Advani expressed broad support for Manmohan Singh’s reforms and the government’s economic policies. Yet, within twenty-four hours of that announcement, the party reversed its stance completely, with Murli Manohar Joshi calling the Union budget ‘highly inflationary’ and ‘anti-poor’. At a time when Narasimha Rao was opening the doors of the economy with liberalisation, Joshi announced 26 March as ‘Anti-Budget Day’ with protest rallies around the country, to be followed by a ‘protest week’ at the level of the states.[69] The party rejected the Dunkel proposals on the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) and wanted them